

I think I just sent money to a scammer

6 findings · 13-step checklist · 3 sources · cheatgrid.com

You already sent money, sometime in the last day, to someone who wasn't who they said they were. Part of you wants to nail down exactly how stupid you were, as if working that out could undo it.

THE GOAL

Do the one thing that might still help, without waiting until you've fully explained to yourself how this happened.

CHECKLIST

The moment it clicks that this was a scam, within the last day of it happening.

- ☐ Stop replying to them, and don't send anything else, no matter what they say next.
- ☐ If anyone asks for a fee, a deposit, or a "test transfer" to undo the scam, refuse and treat it as more of the same.
- ☐ Screenshot the messages, the profile, and the payment confirmation before you lose access to them.
- ☐ Block their number, profile, or email once you've saved what you need.
- ☐ Write down the date, the amount, and which service carried the payment, in one place you'll use again when you contact them.
- ☐ Call or message your bank, the payment app, or the wire service today, and ask them to look into reversing it.
- ☐ If you shared a password, a code, or let them see your screen, change that password now, starting with email and banking.
- ☐ Turn on extra login verification for your email and banking, if it isn't on already.
- ☐ Ask whoever you just contacted for a reference number or written confirmation, and write it down with today's date.
- ☐ File a short report of what happened somewhere official: when it was, how much, and how you were first contacted.
- ☐ Check your other accounts today for anything else that looks off, and change the password on any that do.
- ☐ If the same person contacts you again with a new excuse, treat it as the same scam continuing, not something new.
- ☐ Pick a specific time today, like after dinner, to come back to this so it isn't running in the back of your mind.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1** Scammers push time pressure and distraction on purpose, and that's what threw off your judgment in the moment. Acting now doesn't have to wait until you've made sense of it.
- 2** Contact whoever moved the money for you, right away, your bank, the payment app, or the wire service. Waiting costs you speed, and that's what matters most here.
- 3** What shakes you afterward **tracks how personal the lie felt**, not the amount of money involved. That part can outlast the money question entirely.

What's actually going on in your head right now

WATCH

Watch for the instant thought that this is entirely your fault. It can be a scammer's script instead.

Interviews with scam victims found that scammers deliberately use blame-shifting lines like 'that's all your fault' to make victims misattribute what happened to themselves. [Source 1](#)

DON'T

Scammers push time pressure and distraction on purpose, and that's what threw off your judgment in the moment. Acting now doesn't have to wait until you've made sense of it.

Time pressure and distraction are scam tactics researchers who interviewed victims found used on purpose, and they impair careful thinking while the scam is happening. [Source 1](#)

Getting the money back

DO

Contact whoever moved the money for you, right away, your bank, the payment app, or the wire service. Waiting costs you speed, and that's what matters most here.

Money usually only moves back through the same channel that sent it, so that's the place still worth asking fast. [Source 2](#)

KNOW

You didn't pick a careless way to pay. Scammers push you toward the hardest option to trace instead.

Scammers deliberately choose payment methods that are hard for anyone to track, which is the whole point of asking for them. [Source 2](#)

What this costs you, and what doesn't decide that

KNOW

What shakes you afterward **tracks how personal the lie felt**, not the amount of money involved. That part can outlast the money question entirely.

Across many separate studies of fraud victims, feeling betrayed predicted distress better than the size of the loss did. [Source 3](#)

KNOW

A single scam can make ordinary money decisions feel harder. That's a documented reaction instead of you becoming paranoid.

Qualitative studies of fraud victims describe this same pulling back from financial and digital activity afterward, alongside less confidence in their own safety. [Source 3](#)

Sources

1. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC9317489/>
2. <https://consumer.ftc.gov/articles/what-do-if-you-were-scammed>
3. <https://www.frontiersin.org/journals/psychology/articles/10.3389/fpsyg.2026.1805536/full>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Scams and fraud at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

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